

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Law English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For lawyers, paralegals, compliance staff, contracts specialists, legal operations teams, and law-adjacent professionals.

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

Admissible

Allowed to be considered by a judge or jury under the rules of evidence.

Allege

State a claim or fact as asserted but not yet proven.

Answer

A defendant's pleading responding to the complaint and often asserting defenses.

Appeal

A request for a higher court to review a lower court's decision.

Assert

State a position, claim, right, defense, or privilege.

Assignment

Transfer of rights, interests, or obligations, depending on context and agreement.

Attorney-client privilege

A legal doctrine protecting certain confidential communications for legal advice.

Audit trail

Records that show who did what, when, and why.

Authority

A legal source used to support analysis, such as a statute, regulation, case, or rule.

Binding authority

Authority a court must follow in the relevant jurisdiction and procedural context.

Board resolution

A formal record of a board decision or authorization.

Burden of proof

The obligation to prove a fact, claim, defense, or element to the required standard.

Claim substantiation

Evidence supporting advertising or marketing claims before they are made.

Compel

Ask or order someone to do something, often through a motion or court order.

Complaint

A pleading that starts a civil lawsuit by stating claims against the defendant.

Condition precedent

An event that must occur before an obligation becomes due.

Confidentiality

The professional duty to protect information relating to a client or matter, subject to applicable rules.

Conflict of interest

A situation where duties to one client, former client, third person, or personal interest may limit representation.

Copyright

Protection for original works fixed in a tangible medium, subject to limits and exceptions.

Covenant

A promise to do or not do something.

Deposition

Out-of-court sworn testimony recorded for use in litigation.

Dicta

Language in an opinion that is not necessary to the holding.

Disclosure

Providing required or relevant information to a party, regulator, investor, court, or public filing.

Discovery

The formal process for obtaining information and evidence from other parties or nonparties.

Distinguish

Explain why a case or authority does not control because facts or law differ materially.

Due diligence

Structured review of facts, documents, obligations, and risks before a transaction or decision.

Enforcement action

A regulator's action to investigate, stop, penalize, or remedy alleged violations.

Engagement letter

A document defining the representation, scope, fees, responsibilities, and sometimes limitations.

Fiduciary duty

A duty of loyalty, care, or good faith owed by someone in a position of trust.

Governing law

The jurisdiction's law selected to interpret and enforce the agreement.

Holding

The rule or principle necessary to the court's decision.

Indemnity

A clause requiring one party to cover certain losses, claims, or liabilities.

Informed consent

Agreement after adequate information about material risks and alternatives.

Interrogatory

A written question served in discovery that must be answered under oath.

Judgment

A final court decision resolving the dispute or a claim.

Jurisdiction

A court's legal authority to hear a matter or exercise power over a party or subject.

License

Permission to use rights or property under specified conditions.

Limitation of liability

A clause limiting the amount or type of damages recoverable.

Material breach

A serious breach that may justify stronger remedies or termination.

Materiality

Importance of information to a legal, regulatory, investor, or business decision.

Motion

A request asking the court to issue an order or take action.

Object

State a legal objection to a question, evidence, request, or procedure.

Order

A court's direction or decision on a matter before it.

Patent

A government-granted right related to an invention, subject to statutory requirements.

Persuasive authority

Authority a court may consider but does not have to follow.

Precedent

A prior decision used as legal authority for later cases.

Preserve

Keep evidence, rights, arguments, or objections from being lost.

Privilege

A legal protection that may permit withholding certain communications or materials.

Reasonable accommodation

A workplace adjustment considered under disability laws, subject to legal standards and facts.

Remediation

Corrective action taken to fix a problem and prevent recurrence.

Representation

A statement of fact made by a party, often used to allocate risk.

Request for production

A discovery request seeking documents, ESI, or tangible things.

Reserve rights

State that a party is not waiving rights or remedies by acting now.

Retainer

An arrangement or payment connected to securing legal services, depending on local rules and agreement terms.

Scope of representation

The agreed boundaries of legal work to be performed.

Settle

Resolve a dispute by agreement rather than final adjudication.

Standard of review

The level of deference an appellate court gives to a lower court's decision.

Stipulate

Agree formally to a fact, issue, procedure, or condition.

Trade secret

Information with economic value from not being generally known and subject to reasonable secrecy efforts.

Trademark

A source identifier such as a word, phrase, symbol, or design for goods or services.

Venue

The proper geographic or court location for a case.

Waiver

Intentional relinquishment of a known right, claim, protection, or objection.

Warranty

A promise or assurance about a fact, condition, product, service, or performance.

Work product

Materials prepared in anticipation of litigation that may receive protection from disclosure.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Give a useful status update

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Offer a workable tradeoff

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Help a group reach a clear next step

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Legal English Mindset: Facts, Issues, Rules, Risk

An internal case note says a supplier "breached the contract." The team has the delivery email but has not reviewed the signed agreement.

The delivery email records a delay. Whether that amounts to a breach requires review of the agreement and relevant law. I'll separate the documented facts from the legal questions in the note.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

02 | Client Intake, Scope, Conflicts, and Confidentiality

A prospective client sends a long description of a dispute and asks for immediate advice. The intake team has not completed its conflict check.

Before we discuss advice, could you provide the names of the parties and the type of assistance you are seeking? Our team needs to complete intake and confirm the scope of any engagement.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

03 | Litigation Lifecycle: Pleadings, Motions, Deadlines, Strategy

A litigation task list has two dates from different documents. The supervising lawyer has not confirmed which deadline controls.

The task list contains conflicting dates. I have attached both source documents and flagged the issue for your review. Please confirm the controlling deadline before I update the calendar.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

04 | Discovery, ESI, Privilege Review, and Depositions

A document reviewer finds an email chain that may contain privileged communications. It is in a review set, not yet a production set.

Please review this email chain for potential privilege before a production decision. I've identified the participants and relevant messages. I have not made a final privilege determination.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

05 | Legal Research, Authority, and Memo Writing

A draft memo cites one decision as controlling authority. The case came from another jurisdiction and the research is still preliminary.

This decision may help the analysis, but we should not label it binding without checking its authority in the relevant jurisdiction. I'll explain that distinction and identify what further research is needed.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

06 | Contracts, Redlines, and Negotiation

A draft services agreement requires delivery within ten days. The commercial team needs fifteen days and wants the contract team to propose wording.

Our delivery team can commit to fifteen days under the current scope. Could we revise the proposed period accordingly? I'll send the business rationale for legal review with the redline.

Try it again: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

07 | Corporate, Compliance, Regulatory, and Investigation Language

An employee interview contains a report of possible misconduct. A manager asks to describe the allegation as a confirmed violation in a summary.

At this stage, we have an allegation and an interview record. The finding is not established. I'll use neutral wording and identify the questions that the investigation still needs to resolve.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

08 | Advocacy, Settlement, Ethics, and Professional Judgment

Two team members disagree about settlement priorities. One prioritizes timing; the other prioritizes confidentiality. Counsel is preparing for a client discussion.

Let's separate the objectives before discussing terms. How important are timing and confidentiality to the client? We can present the options and their implications for the client's instructions.

Try it again: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Use the language responsibly

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

US Courts: glossary of legal terms

<https://www.uscourts.gov/glossary>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.